

71 Labs — Founding & Operating Model Meeting Notes

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Purpose: Align on what 71 Labs is being built to become, how it will operate, its initial product/revenue priorities, team structure, research direction, and the systems required to run it effectively.

1. Executive Summary

The discussion established 71 Labs as a **progressive product, research, and technology venture lab** designed to repeatedly turn ideas, research, technology, people, and capital into useful products and revenue-generating opportunities.

The intention is not for 71 Labs to simply become another version of Talise. **Talise represents an initial proof of work and proof of capability:** evidence that the team can identify a problem, build technology, ship a product, compete in ecosystems, and create opportunities.

71 Labs is intended to take that capability and make it **repeatable and structured**.

The proposed model is broadly:

Research → Ideas → Validation → Prototyping → Product → Market → Revenue → Scale / Spin-out / Kill → Reinvest → Repeat

The immediate focus is to establish the structure required to execute this model, while using the October–December period to build products, generate leads, pursue opportunities/hackathons, and increase capital.

A major theme from the discussion was that **activity is not the goal; output and consistent ROI are**.

2. What 71 Labs Is Becoming

71 Labs is being developed as a lab that can:

- Research emerging technologies and identify practical opportunities.
- Build software products and eventually physical products.
- Participate in hackathons as a source of funding, discovery, partnerships, and product opportunities.

- Work with organizations, businesses, and individuals to identify and solve problems.
- Generate leads and convert opportunities into revenue.
- Build internal products that can become independent businesses.
- Combine technology, human capability, ideas, and capital to create measurable returns.
- Continuously experiment with new technologies rather than relying on one technology or product category.

The exact formal classification of 71 Labs still needs to be defined e.g. venture studio, R&D lab, product studio, technology company, or another structure.

That distinction should be resolved as part of the foundational work.

3. Relationship Between Talise and 71 Labs

Talise should be viewed as an important **proof of capability**, rather than the permanent definition of 71 Labs.

Talise demonstrates that the team can:

- Build and ship technology.
- Work within emerging ecosystems.
- Enter hackathons and competitive environments.
- Develop products around real problems.
- Create relationships with ecosystems, funders, and potential partners.

Marin is another opportunity to demonstrate this capability, particularly through the Mezo/grant route.

The broader objective is to move from:

“We built Talise.”

to:

“We have a system that allows us to repeatedly build valuable things.”

71 Labs is intended to be that system.

4. Immediate Strategic Priorities: October–December

The first three months should be treated as a focused build-and-capital-generation period.

Primary priorities

1. Build and ship the initial product portfolio.
2. Generate leads.
3. Pursue relevant hackathons and funding opportunities.
4. Convert opportunities into revenue.
5. Establish the operating structure of the lab.
6. Build documentation and knowledge systems.
7. Establish clear team responsibilities.
8. Track spending, resources, and ROI.
9. Complete the formal setup/registration of 71 Labs.
10. Create the foundation from which deeper R&D can happen.

There is currently a target of **five quality products by early October**.

This should be treated as a target rather than an assumption. The exact definition of “complete,” the scope of each product, their owners, and their delivery dates need to be clarified.

5. Product Development Engine

One of the major systems 71 Labs needs to establish is a repeatable process for deciding what to build.

A proposed product lifecycle is:

Idea → Research → Validation → Prototype → MVP → Market Test → Revenue → Scale / Spin-out / Kill

The lab needs clear criteria for moving between each stage.

Questions to establish:

- Where do product ideas come from?
- What makes an idea worth researching?
- How much validation is required before building?
- What qualifies as an MVP?
- How do we determine whether a product has real demand?
- When do we stop investing in a product?
- When does a product become its own business?
- What happens to products that do not achieve market traction?
- How do we prevent building simply because something is technically interesting?

The aim should be to **reduce wasted resources while increasing the number of valuable outputs produced.**

6. Research & R&D Direction

Research is a core component of 71 Labs.

The lab should actively monitor and experiment with emerging technologies, particularly where there is a realistic opportunity to turn research into products, capabilities, or competitive advantage.

Potential research areas discussed include:

- Artificial intelligence
- Blockchain
- Robotics
- Quantum computing
- Engineering
- Agriculture
- Livestock
- Manufacturing
- Automation
- Other emerging technologies

AI Research

AI should not simply be treated as a tool for completing existing tasks.

71 Labs should actively research:

- New models.
- New AI products and platforms.
- Image/video generation.
- AI-assisted software development.
- Agentic workflows.
- New model capabilities.
- How to combine different AI tools.
- Practical limitations of emerging models.
- How these tools can improve product development and operations.

The objective is to understand **what new technology can actually do and how far its capabilities can be pushed**, then document and apply the findings.

This also means budgeting for access to relevant tools and models where necessary.

Research system still to be defined

The lab needs a research backlog containing:

Research question → Experiment → Findings → Documentation → Potential application

A completed research cycle should produce something useful, whether that is a product opportunity, technical capability, operational improvement, or a decision not to pursue something.

7. Hackathon Engine

Hackathons are expected to be more than competitions.

They can serve as:

- Product discovery.
- Funding opportunities.
- Proof of work.
- Lead generation.
- Ecosystem entry.
- Partnership opportunities.
- Market validation.
- Sources of ideas that can later become commercial products.

71 Labs should therefore develop a repeatable hackathon process:

Opportunity discovery → Selection → Team formation → Build → Submission → Follow-up → Commercialization

An important question is what happens **after** a hackathon.

Winning or placing should not be the end goal if the resulting product has commercial potential.

The lab needs a process for determining:

- Which hackathon opportunities are worth pursuing.
- How many can be pursued simultaneously.
- Which projects become products.
- Which projects are abandoned after the competition.
- How funding/winnings are reinvested.

8. Team Structure

The initial team is expected to be approximately **4-5 people**, depending on the skills available.

The discussion identified the need to map existing team members against the work required for October–December.

Potential functional areas include:

- Engineering
- Product
- Product design
- Design experience
- Research/R&D
- Operations
- Growth/Sales
- Finance
- Project/product coordination

Product design and design experience should be considered distinct capabilities rather than automatically treating design as one function.

The team should remain lean, but each person should have clear ownership.

Immediate requirement

Map:

Person → Skills → Role → Projects → Responsibilities → Gaps

This will make it easier to determine whether the current team can realistically deliver the October–December plan or whether additional people need to be brought in.

9. Operations & the “Second Brain” Function

A significant issue identified during the discussion was the weakness of operational structure and the tendency for too much information/work to become centralized.

The goal should be to avoid repeating that pattern.

The operations function should help create visibility across:

- What is being built.
- Who owns it.

- What is due.
- What is blocked.
- What has been completed.
- What decisions are pending.
- What research is happening.
- What opportunities are being pursued.
- What resources are being spent.
- What needs Eromonsele's (my baby's) attention.

The “second brain” role discussed for Vanessa should therefore be understood as **strategic operations and coordination**, rather than simply administrative task management.

The purpose is to help maintain context across the lab, identify gaps and bottlenecks, structure information, identify partnerships, follow leads and proposals, ask the questions that may otherwise be missed, and keep work moving.

The aim is ultimately to reduce unnecessary centralization around Eromonsele while keeping him informed about the things that genuinely require his input.

10. Proposed Operating Workflow

Before the team begins operating fully, 71 Labs needs a basic operating rhythm.

This should include:

Daily / ongoing

- Task updates.
- Blockers.
- Important decisions.
- Project communication.

Weekly

- Stand-up / team review.
- Product progress.
- Research progress.
- Sales/leads.
- Hackathon opportunities.
- Financial/resource review.
- Upcoming priorities.

Per project

- Owner.
- Objective.
- Scope.
- Deadline.
- Current stage.
- Dependencies.
- Blockers.
- Success criteria.

Documentation

Important information should not remain exclusively inside individual conversations or people's memories.

There should be a central source of truth for:

- Company context.
- Product documentation.
- Research.
- Decisions.
- Tasks.
- Meeting notes.
- Financial information.
- Partnerships.
- Outreach.
- Processes.

11. Proposed Tool Stack

Google Meet + Gemini

Proposed for meetings because the team is likely to operate through Google Meet and Gemini can support meeting recording, transcription, summaries, and documentation.

The intention is to make meeting information easier to capture and turn into usable documentation rather than relying on manual note-taking.

Jira

Proposed by Vanessa as the project/task management system.

Potential uses:

- Backlog.
- Task assignment.
- Sprint planning.
- Product development.
- Project tracking.
- Follow-ups.
- Engineering work.
- Visibility across projects.

Jira should function as the **execution layer**, not the entire knowledge base.

Eromonsele can validate Jira against alternatives before final adoption.

Slack

Proposed as the primary day-to-day team communication layer.

Potential structure:

- General/company channel.
- Product-specific channels.
- Research.
- Engineering.
- Growth/sales.
- Operations.
- Announcements.

The purpose is to prevent important work communication from becoming scattered across personal messages.

12. Revenue, Capital & ROI

71 Labs is not being built simply to produce projects.

The broader financial objective is to turn:

Human capital + financial capital + technology + ideas → products/opportunities → revenue → increased capital

Potential sources include:

- Product revenue.
- Hackathon winnings.

- Grants.
- External client work.
- Partnerships.
- Licensing.
- Commercialization of internal products.
- Other technology opportunities.

Financial discipline is therefore important from the beginning.

Each project should eventually have visibility into:

- Resources invested.
- Money spent.
- People involved.
- Expected return.
- Actual return.
- Strategic value.

The guiding principle discussed was **consistent ROI rather than activity for activity's sake**.

13. Sales, Leads & External Opportunities

71 Labs should actively build an external pipeline rather than waiting for opportunities to appear.

This includes:

- Identifying potential organizations/businesses.
- Generating leads.
- Developing tailored pitches.
- Building relationships with founders and decision-makers.
- Using events for targeted networking.
- Demonstrating existing capabilities.
- Converting conversations into projects, partnerships, or revenue.

For the upcoming event activity:

- Compile an Excel sheet of relevant speakers/founders.
- Identify why each person is relevant.
- Prepare tailored outreach pitches.
- Complete the required free demo.
- Follow up with Robert Zarium.

The objective is **targeted outreach**, not simply collecting contacts.

14. Product / Online Store Workflow

A Shopify-style store template was discussed as part of the initial product work.

The workflow should eventually make it possible to take a brand/product's information and efficiently populate the store structure.

Ellie is expected to review the available store templates and provide feedback.

A potential workflow is:

Brand/Product Information → Structured Extraction → LLM-assisted Processing → Store Template → Review → Launch

The store experience should also account for the Nigerian market, including appropriate payments and currency.

15. Legal & Corporate Foundation

Formal registration of 71 Labs remains outstanding.

The foundational work should clarify:

- Appropriate entity structure.
- Registration.
- Licensing requirements.
- Ownership.
- Intellectual property.
- Contracts.
- Relevant compliance requirements.
- Domain/SEO.
- Public-facing company/outreach page.

Vanessa will help Eromonsele determine the appropriate route for registration.

16. Foundation Questions We Still Need to Answer

Before the operating system is finalized, these questions should be answered.

Identity

- What exactly is 71 Labs?
- What does “71” represent?
- Why does 71 Labs exist?
- What is its mission?
- What is its vision?
- What should 71 Labs be known for?
- What are its core operating principles?
- What is 71 Labs explicitly **not**?

Strategy

- What is the 1-year vision?
- What is the 3-year vision?
- What is the 5-year vision?
- What types of products should the lab prioritize?
- What types of opportunities should it reject?

Products

- What are the five initial products?
- What stage is each currently at?
- Who owns each?
- What is the deadline?
- What does “complete” mean for each?
- What is the expected commercial outcome?

Research

- Which research areas are priority now?
- Which are later?
- How are research opportunities selected?
- How are AI tools/models evaluated?
- Where are findings documented?
- How does research become product development?

Team

- Who is currently on the team?
- What does each person do best?
- What role does each person own?
- What skills are missing?
- Which roles are full-time?
- Which can be project-based?

Operations

- What should Eromonsele see daily?
- What should he see weekly?
- Which decisions require his approval?
- What can be delegated?
- What exactly should Vanessa own as the second brain?
- What information must always be documented?

Revenue

- What is the October–December revenue/capital target?
- Who is the target customer?
- How will leads be generated?
- How will leads be tracked?
- What is the sales process?
- How will ROI be measured?

Hackathons

- What qualifies as a worthwhile hackathon?
- How many can the team pursue simultaneously?
- How do we choose projects?
- What happens after a hackathon?
- When does a hackathon project become a commercial product?

Operating system

- What is the single source of truth?
- How will Jira/Slack/Google Docs work together?
- What is the meeting cadence?
- How are blockers escalated?
- How are decisions recorded?

17. Action Items

Owner	Action	Timing / Status
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Eromonsele	Complete remaining Marin submissions following rejected iOS TestFlight build	Immediate
Eromonsele	Prepare Marin for testing and audit-related review	By end of week
Eromonsele	Map team members' skills against October–December work	Before team planning
Eromonsele / Vanessa	Define first three months of products, schedules, stand-ups and tasks	Before kickoff
Eromonsele	Share Marin documentation for review	Pending
Eromonsele / Vanessa	Research/validate Jira or alternative project-management tool	Pending
Eromonsele & Vanessa	Document 71 Labs' purpose, goals, research direction and operating approach	Before launch
Eromonsele & Vanessa	Prepare initial 71 Labs structure/context	Before planned kickoff

Vanessa	Prepare outreach pitches for selected speakers/founders	Upcoming event
Vanessa	Compile Excel sheet of relevant speakers/founders	Upcoming event
Eromonsele	Complete free demo required for outreach	Pending
Eromonsele	Contact Robert Zarium	Pending
Eromonsele	Complete initial target of five 71 Labs products	Early October target
Ellie	Review online-store templates and provide feedback	Pending
Eromonsele	Develop workflow for extracting brand/product details into store template	Pending
Eromonsele	Move forward with formal registration of 71 Labs	Pending
Vanessa + Eromonsele	Determine appropriate route for 71 Labs registration	Pending

18. Immediate Next Step

Rather than immediately trying to build every system, the recommended sequence is:

1. Define 71 Labs

Identity, purpose, vision, mission, values, scope and relationship to Talise.

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2. Define the operating model

How the lab turns ideas and research into products, revenue and repeatable output.

↓

3. Map the team

People, skills, roles, ownership and gaps.

↓

4. Define the October–December plan

Products, hackathons, research, sales, revenue and milestones.

↓

5. Set up the operating system

Documentation, meetings, workflows, task management, communication and reporting.

↓

6. Implement the tools

Google Meet/Gemini + Jira + Slack + Google Drive/Docs or equivalent knowledge base.

↓

7. Execute and review

Weekly review of product progress, leads, revenue, research, blockers and ROI.

Working Principle

The central operating principle coming out of the meeting is:

71 Labs should optimize for valuable output and repeatable ROI, not activity.

The goal is not simply to build more things, attend more hackathons, conduct more research, or have more meetings.

The goal is to create a system capable of repeatedly turning **ideas, research, technology, people and capital into valuable products and opportunities.**